

When forcing harmony creates error

Matthew 7:20

In the post-resurrection timeline of Jesus Christ our Lord written of in all four gospels ([Matthew 28:16-20](#), [Mark 16:14-20](#), [Luke 24:36-53](#), [John 20:19-25 & 26-31](#)) the Lord visits the disciples on several occasions.

Many study Bibles and commentators appear to attempt to harmonize these accounts with each other in various fashions. Most of them do so by explicitly listing or assuming that some are parallel passages in their exegesis. And of course there's nothing wrong with that in and of itself. The problems arises when we simply don't check our Bible carefully enough.

The specific account we will be looking at today is when anyone attempts to assert that both [Luke 24:36-53](#) and [John 20:19-25](#) (first visit) are parallel passages.

Here are a few of the sources that either claim or assume that they are parallel passages:

- **Study Bibles**
 - The King James Study Bible
 - The Scofield Reference Bible
 - The Henry Morris Study Bible
 - The Ryrie Study Bible
 - The New Oxford Annotated Bible
 - The Anchor Bible (Raymond Brown)
 - The MacArthur Bible
 - The Thompson Chain-Reference Bible
 - ESV Study Bible
 - The Reformation Study Bible
- **Commentaries**
 - Matthew Henry
 - John Gill
 - Adam Clarke
 - Jamieson, Fausset, and Brown (JFB)
- **Other writings**
 - The Expositor's Greek Testament
 - Bengel's Gnomon of the New Testament
- **Historical writings**
 - Tatian's Diatessaron (c. 160-175AD)
 - Augustine of Hippo (*De consensu evangelistarum*)
 - The Eusebian Canons

Our first stop is [John 20:24](#) which identifies Thomas called Didymus as one of “*the twelve*”.

John 20:24

But Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, was not with them when Jesus came.

And then we define the phrase “*the twelve*”:

Matthew 10:2-4 ² Now the names of the twelve apostles are these; The first, Simon, who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother; James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother; ³ Philip, and Bartholomew; Thomas, and Matthew the publican; James the son of Alphaeus, and Lebbaeus, whose surname was Thaddaeus; ⁴ Simon the Canaanite, and Judas Iscariot, who also betrayed him.	Mark 3:14-19 ¹⁴ And he ordained twelve, that they should be with him, and that he might send them forth to preach, ¹⁵ And to have power to heal sicknesses, and to cast out devils: ¹⁶ And Simon he surnamed Peter; ¹⁷ And James the son of Zebedee, and John the brother of James; and he surnamed them Boanerges, which is, The sons of thunder: ¹⁸ And Andrew, and Philip, and Bartholomew, and Matthew, and Thomas, and James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus, and Simon the Canaanite, ¹⁹ And Judas Iscariot, which also betrayed him: and they went into an house.	Luke 6:13-16 ¹³ And when it was day, he called unto him his disciples: and of them he chose twelve, whom also he named apostles; ¹⁴ Simon, (whom he also named Peter,) and Andrew his brother, James and John, Philip and Bartholomew, ¹⁵ Matthew and Thomas, James the son of Alphaeus, and Simon called Zelotes, ¹⁶ And Judas the brother of James, and Judas Iscariot, which also was the traitor.
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- The Bible defines “*the twelve*” as twelve distinct men and nothing else.
 - There is zero evidence **from the Bible** to suggest it ever means anything else.
- Thomas called Didymus is one of those twelve men.

Now, if we look carefully at the [Luke](#) account ([Luke 24:36-53](#)) we will notice something very interesting in the preceding verses:

Luke 24:33

And they ^[the two disciples that went to Emmaus] rose up the same hour, and returned to Jerusalem, and found the eleven gathered together, and them that were with them,

This verse is critical because it describes who is present when Jesus appears in this account:

- The two disciples from Emmaus.
- The eleven.
- Them that were with the eleven.

This precise point is where many commentators diverge in **their opinion** on what the Bible says. And so it is necessarily a critical point where one has to decide whether to take the Bible literally or not. My suggestion is that you set aside all human **opinions** and instead submit yourself to the only reliable discerner between truth and error ([1Cor 2:14](#), [Hebrew 4:12](#)).

When those two disciples returned from Emmaus they found “*the eleven gathered together*”. Who exactly are “*the eleven*”?

The phrase “*the eleven*” appears exactly six times in six verses in the New Testament.

Matthew 28:16

Then **the eleven** disciples went away into Galilee, into a mountain where Jesus had appointed them.

Mark 16:14

Afterward he appeared unto **the eleven** as they sat at meat, and upbraided them with their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they believed not them which had seen him after he was risen.

Luke 24:9

And returned from the sepulchre, and told all these things unto **the eleven**, and to all the rest.

Luke 24:33

And they rose up the same hour, and returned to Jerusalem, and found **the eleven** gathered together, and them that were with them,

Acts 1:26

And they gave forth their lots; and the lot fell upon Matthias; and he was numbered with **the eleven** apostles.

Acts 2:14

But Peter, standing up with **the eleven**, lifted up his voice, and said unto them, Ye men of Judaea, and all ye that dwell at Jerusalem, be this known unto you, and hearken to my words:

- Every usage of “*the eleven*” is equivalent to “*the twelve*” **excluding** Judas Iscariot.
 - There is zero evidence **from the Bible** to suggest it ever means anything else so where did some of the other sources get this idea?
- That means that Thomas called Didymus is both one of “*the twelve*” and one of “*the eleven*”.

So why are all these simple facts so important? If we look very carefully near the end of the first visit in the **John** account (**John 20:19-25**) we see the following:

John 20:24

But Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, **was not with them when Jesus came**.

- Thomas called Didymus **was not there** for the first visit in **John 20**.

To summarize, Thomas **was** there in **Luke 24:36-53** and he **was not** there in **John 20:19-25**. This very simple fact teaches us that they **are not** parallel passages.

Some commentators attempt to “force the harmony” of these two accounts by asserting that the phrase “*the eleven*” is **figurative** and doesn’t mean “all of the eleven disciples”. Unfortunately, there is no Biblical evidence to support that assertion.

Side note: as a consequence of what we have learned we also learn that **John 21:14**’s “*third time*” count is constrained to the book of **John** and is not a total across the gospels.